Thoughts On Wing Commander: Privateer

By kingmakeress on CIC

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Notes: This document comes from my **github**. Therein I also host my **articles** on retro games as well as the *Wing Commander* **fanfic** I am currently editing named *Vega Campaign*.

1. Introduction

Privateer is a different view on the *Wing Commander* universe where, surprisingly perhaps, the Terran-Kilrathi war still plays a major role in the story, but it is at the background. This happens because the hero, Grayson Burrows or Brownhair, is a freelancer operating in the Gemini sector, a relatively minor theater of operations. This fact allows for a more carefree civilian life compared to the Vega or the Enigma sectors named in the main war storyline. Of course, this holds as long as the systems along the border are avoid. Otherwise, the closer the player flies to them, the more likely Kilrathi are to appear. Not to mention stray pilots or even small Kilrathi flight groups venturing into Confederation space.

Being at the fringe of the Terran space, this frontier life is far from being uneventful with pirates roaming Gemini to pray on merchants across established trade routes, especially around their hidden bases where they operate *en masse* with almost total impunity. Moreover, the rather militant Retros, an offshoot of the peaceful Church of Man, despise anything based on technology even remotely. So when they more than occasionally appear in space, where everything from breathing to communicating and navigating inevitably relies on technology, they are there to disrupt literally everything.

In this chaotic environment the local militias in light fighters, assisted on occasion by Confederation InSys troops flying far more advanced crafts such as agile fighters, tough bombers, and even corvettes armed with a wide array of guns, are trying to maintain law and order by hunting down anyone carrying contraband or attacking merchants. As the local and Confederation forces are often vastly outnumbered, they resort to getting help from mercenaries who have their own fighters and tactics.

Where does Brownhair stand in all this? The answer is really open, as he is bound only by budgetary constraints and by your decisions. In Gemini only these shape your actions and your destiny …

2. Structure

This document was literally written while replaying *Privateer* and its add-on *Righteous Fire* probably for the millionth time as it is based on notes taken on the spot. Thus, some pieces of information may be missing or parts of the text may feel as if they were hastily written, probably because they in fact were. This is why I have been and will keep revisiting this document. Moreover, at the end of the text there is a dedicated section with links to additional resources. The **Playtester's Guide**, which I recently read, needs little introduction and contains a plethora of interesting facts about the game as, perhaps more importantly, it is written in a way similar to the spirit of the game.

This structure of this document is linear and the sections can be read independently, much like the initial plot missions in *Righteous Fire*. Specifically this document contains the following:

- Section 3 some basic information about the Gemini section are given as well as navigational points of interest, some trade routes I have discovered, and some strike routes to Kamekhs.
- Section 4 contains notes on the game and ideas for possible plot missions, extending the existing game mechanics, and adding unique capabilities to each ship.
- Finally, section 5 has various thoughts on the *Wing Commander* universe encompassing all games I have played so far and they are not necessarily related to *Privateer*.

In the various lists Gemini locations are sorted first by quadrant and then alphabetically by system name for easier lookup. Hyperlinks are in gray and bold font to remain salient while avoiding page cluttering and preserving the minimalist grayscale aesthetic of this document. Also, although *Righteous Fire* (or RF for short) is an add-on to *Privateer*, I treat it as a separate game.

It is probably a sign of the times, but I should clearly state that no AI has been used in making this text with the sole exception of some filters used in the art presented in subsection 4.7.

Warning: Lots of spoilers ahead, especially in section 3. You may enjoy the game more if you try a mission one (or several) time(s) and discover the *Privateer* universe yourself before reading that section.

3. Gemini

3.1. The sector

The Gemini sector is the place where both games take place and it is divided into four quadrants as shown below, each with its own distinct traits which determine how easy or not certain flying styles and strategies are viable. A full map of the sector at the start of the game can be found **here**. A broader map encompassing the entire Wing Commander universe and putting everything in context is **here**.

- **Fariss (Upper left in the first map above):** Asteroids and pirate bases.
- **Humboldt (Lower left):** The player starts here. Sort of the backwater area of Gemini.
- **Potter (Lower right):** Is the heart of the sector as it has three major bases, namely the New Constantinople, the New Detroit, and Oxford, as well as many lucrative trade routes.
- **Clarke (Upper right):** Has the Kilrathi border and the Perry naval base.

3.2. Pirate bases

Pirate bases are not shown in the player's map, but once you jump in the respective system they show up in the comms with their own distinct messages. They offer mostly contraband and some unique luxury items plus they are part of plot missions in both games. Be careful of large militia of militia and Confed patrols in the neighboring systems, especially next to Pentonville. It seems that the authorities, "rife with corruption" as Roman Lynch himself would say, know where approximately the problem is but they are unable or unwilling to deal with the root cause. Also note that contraband cannot be sold in New Constantinople or in Perry, but New Detroit is perfectly fine.

- Drake in Capella.
- Meggido in Telar.
- Smallville in KM-252.
- Oakham in Pentonville.
- Tuck's in Sherwood.

3.3. Navigation

3.3.1. Asteroids

Asteroids are one of the few constants in Wing Commander. Regarding the asteroids in Gemini, this list is far from being exhaustive as I have written only the most annoying nav points.

- Delta nav 3 [plot].
- Pender's Star nav 2.
- Pestilence nav 2 [RF plot].
- War nav 1 and 3 [RF plot].
- Skip Famine nav 4 whenever possible [RF plot].

The Pender's Star nav point is the only real nuisance when going from Troy to New Constantinople when flying in a Tarsus aside from a random pirate group of four Talons in Junction.

3.3.2. Hidden nav points

Throughout Gemini there are scattered some hidden nav points which from a gaming perspective are regular nav points which do not appear on maps.

- 17-AR between nav points 1 and 2 [RF plot].
- Castor between nav points 1 and 2 [plot].
- Freyja between nav points 1 and 2 [RF plot].
- Pollux between nav points 1 and 3 [asteroids].
- Rikel between nav points 2 and 3 [RF plot].
- Shangri La [Potter] between nan points 1 and 2.

3.3.3. Points of interest

Some points of interests in Gemini which do not fit in the above lists are the following.

- Troy is an easy system to give new players a chance.
- The two mining bases in Troy, Achilles and Hector, have no asteroids [starting system].
- Romulus mining base has no asteroids [plot].
- Charon mining base has no asteroids [RF plot].
- Rygannon mining base has no asteroids [plot].
- Mjolnar agricultural base has asteroids [RF plot].
- The Rikel system has **lots** of asteroids [plot].

3.4. Kamekhs [wip]

For all its special nature, *Privateer* is still at heart a *Wing Commander* game, so inevitably Kilrathi are around. Besides being occasional objectives of random missions in various systems in random missions, even at the heart of Gemini which indirectly shows the state of war, they frequently appear along the border. Kamekh corvettes offer additional firepower to these patrols.

The nav points where I have spotted Kamekhs are the following:

- Gamma nav 4 [plot, asteroids].
- Mah'Rahn nav 1 [RF, asteroids].

Note that some of the nav points mentioned above are also mentioned in subsection 3.5. Besides the Taryn Cross plot mission, Kamekhs appear at random like any other space opponent.

3.5. Routes

This subsection contains trade routes I made throughout Gemini as well as various strike missions against Kilrathi in general and Kamekhs in particular. If you are not in good terms with the mercenaries guild or with the authorities in Gemini, shooting down many Kilrathi appeases them.

Short border circle: It is a circular route which includes Perry, Tingerhoff, CMF-A, Nitir, and back. Alternatively, from Nitir you can branch out to Blockade Point Tango and from there to Lisaac or the single point system Mah'Rahn. Be careful as of the asteroids in Blockade Point Tango and Lisaac.

Long border circle: A long circular route which is rather exciting. Take off from Perry and fly successively to Surtur, Blockade Point Charlie, Hyades, Sumn'Kpta, Tr'Pakh, Blockade Point Alpha, Ragnarok, and back to Perry. You are guaranteed to encounter many Kilrathi and possibly some Kamekhs. Make sure to land in Charon in the Haydes system, otherwise you will run out of jump drive fuel in the middle of that circle. Also, note there is no ship dealer on Charon, so be very careful.

Besides the third plot mission from Taryn Cross, Kamekhs appear rather regularly along the Gemini frontier both in *Privateer* and in *Righterous Fire*. For nav points where Kamekhs may appear, see subsection 3.4.

Three quadrants trade route: It is a rather lucrative circular trade route which can be done more than once because of the high demand of the commodities involved as well as because of the distance between them. Be careful if you are flying a Tarsus or a Galaxy as after Perry you will have no access to a ship dealer.

- Start from New Dertoit. Take home appliances and food dispensers.
- Fly to Perry. Sell your cargo and buy weapons. Lots of them as Neo would say.
- Go to Smallville in KM-252, sell the weapons, and pick up brilliance or ultimate. Smallville has no asteroids, there is minimal militia presence in Nexus, and the trip is very short.
- Proceed to Macabee, sell the contraband and pick up gems, uranium, and plutonium. Also choose cargo missions to New Detroit from the public mission computer or from the merchant's guild.
- Return to New Detroit and sell your cargo.

Although this is a long trade route, it is well worth the effort. Also, it gives you a good tour of a large portion of the sector, allowing you to familiarize yourself with many systems.

3.6. Tips

- Don't get blown up as any sane bartender will tell you.
- Tayla 4: If you don't feel like fighting Riordan inside an asteroid field, he will reappear once you jump out of Pentronville.
- Lynch 1: You don't actually have to shoot down Ceiling. Just jump out. He won't follow you.
- RF Masterson 2: Fly to Perry nav points 4 and 5 to eliminate the scripted enemies.
- RF Murphy mission 4: There are two routes from New Constantinople to Metsor. Use them both to take out the scripted enemies at both XXN-1927 and Newcastle.
- RF Monte to Capella: Scripted enemies at 8 and 9 of New Detroit.
- RF Monte to Nexus: Scripted enemies at Tingerhoff and also in Junction jump points leading to Nexus.
- RF final plot mission: There is a secret nav point close to where Mordecai Jones shows up. It leads to Rikel between nav points 4 and 5. If you return to Rikel, the nav point is still there and works.

4. Notes

The material and ideas presented here is a compilation of posts on the Wing Commander CIC as well as of notes I took while replaying *Privateer* a considerable number of times. The material from these posts has been edited and revised to improve their readability.

4.1. Ships

- I would love to see the cut ship, intended to be available to the player as a **speeder**, to be coded in remakes of the game, as it would allow for time sensitive missions requiring agility and stealth. For instance, Captain Goodin may ask you to fly critical supplies and counterattack plans to a Confederation planet currently under Kilrathi blockade or to pick up said plans from a courier.
- I really love the Centurion, but I believe it is slightly overpowered with its four guns and two missile/torpedo launchers. So maybe Orion should get besides her strong shields a unique attack advantage. Maybe a scaled down/early gun cooler to be able to fire more blasts from the heavier guns, say at 1.2 or 1.5 times the original fire rate. I really like the ionic pulse cannon, despite its slow travelling bolts, so I would like to find a use for it.
- Adding a stormfire cannon would be fun, especially for the Orion which can carry additional rounds compared to the Centurion as it has more internal space. So mounting a stormfire in the single external fore hardpoint of Orion with a considerable number of rounds would make sense as Orion is labeled as a mercenary gunship. Ok, Talons may well evade it and maybe Dralthis to some extent, but everything else .. After all why waste stormfire rounds on Talons?

- Additionally, there can be a third, more advanced and considerably more expensive repair droid which can actually manufacture a small number of rounds for stormfire when not busy repairing the ship. Maybe in Righteous Fire, but I could also see that in Privateer. Also the player should have the necessary material aboard, perhaps iron or tungsten and gems. So there is an additional incentive for visiting the numerous mining bases scattered throughout Gemini.
- As for Galaxy, well not my favorite ship. Even for Ultimate (is that a pun on Ultima?) sugar runs I use Orion and just use afterburners to get past militia patrols in Humboldt early in the game to make a quick profit. I guess it is ok for merchants, but remotely controlling the upper and lower turrets, at least partially, from the cockpit would offset to some extent its size and lack of agility. It is not a fighting ship, but it should stand a chance against four or even five Talons.
- Maybe I am thinking of *Dune* or *Elite* here: Galaxy may also be equipped with an exclusive (and expensive) droid additional to the repair one which can process special types of asteroids tractored in.
- There may be modifications reducing the radar cross section of the player's ship, roughly equivalent to an ECM pack 3.5.
- Inspired from WC4 Peleus missions, there may be radar jamming devices used by capital ships giving to the player static up to 20% of the time. There may be smaller such devices used by larger ships like the Galaxy or the Orion giving static 10% of the time.

4.2. Opponents

- Ok so (former!) Governor Menesch sold myriads of Talons to pirates and retros, but why not some of these Gladius too? Or maybe some Broadswords used as pirate semi-capital or scout or coordination ships along with some Galaxies in the same role, after all we have seen the *Black Rhombus*.
- Also it would make sense that the retros occasionally fly Orions and Centurions as heavier fighters, after all they are in the open market.
- Miggs flying a Talon? No. I mean I doubt he can efficiently fly a Centurion, but at least for prestige reasons he and his associates should fly ones.
- Also Miggs should have more friends with him, hoping to intimidate Brownhair, though I doubt be really wants the artifact.
- For immersion reasons, some of the pirate, militia, and Confederation crafts should be randomly damaged indicating a tough patrol.
- In the Fariss and Humboldt quadrants in particular, the player could randomly meet pirates doing business with dirty cops, so Brownhair has to eliminate ships of both factions. These can be plot missions alternatively.
- To further enhance immersion through player achievements, the kill breakdown should include the number of ace pilots as well as the number of capital ships for each faction downed by the player.

4.3. Missions

- In addition to system patrol missions, there should be system wipe missions aiming at eliminating all hostilities. These should be more likely to appear in smaller systems either closer to the Gemini frontier or to pirate bases.
- There should be bounties placed on flight groups.
- Defend base missions? Why not also an obliterate base one? Captain Goodin may well pay you to devastate a pirate base, giving strong vibes of the final Venice mission. After all, they are many of them in Fariss and in Humboldt quadrants, so one can be chosen at random. For this you will need at least five proton torpedoes and strong guns, ie ionic pulse cannons or plasma guns.
- Bring some Wing Commander vibes by flying escort for Paradigms or Broadswords. The game mechanics are already there from the Oxford plot missions.
- Turrets on asteroids around pirate bases armed with lasers or mass drivers. It would make perfect sense, especially in conjunction with the above.

- When the player talks to a bartender the first time after they dispatch Miggs, they could get a note from Lynch that this is not over. That would utilize the existing bar mechanic.
- There should be "system sheriff" side quests where the player acts as one for a predetermined number of missions.
- The scripted enemies in some of the cargo missions should not appear at the destination base as the player can just bypass them and land, even on a Tarsus. Maybe they should attack when the player takes off.
- Tractor Garrovick in under pirates attacking in waves. That should make this mission more interesting and may yield some information about a hidden nav point leading to a system named Epsilon which may be explored in a sequel.
- When going to Perry in both games, there should be a sizeable corrupt Confed patrol waiting to ambush the player when they jump in the system.

4.4. Maps and navigation

- As the player flies in the various systems, the hidden points and the asteroids are marked in Brownhair's star charts. This would give a sense of accomplishment to the player.
- If the player buys the entire star map pack, then the maps for the quadrants other then one the player currently is may contain random errors.
- If the player lands on a pirate base, then it is marked on their star maps. In subsequent militia or Confederation contraband check, these altered maps will show up and the player is marked as a pirate by that particular patrol as if they were carrying contraband.
- On pirate bases, random fixers may sell treasure maps which may or may not be hoaxes. The treasure places may well be asteroid fields in say Rikel (a perfect place for that) or along the Kilrathi border.
- Alternatively these fixers may offer random upgrades to the player's ship. Some may be temporary e.g. a Mace missile or thrust enhancement through a used up device which can only withstand some mileage, whereas other may be permanent but not game changing e.g. tweaking the power generator to give 5% or 10% more energy.
- Once the Informant programs the Eden nav point to the player's computer, it also becomes available to the game. Thus, ordinary patrol, attack, and scout missions from either the mission computer or the mercenaries guild include it and treat it as an ordinary nav point. From an in-universe perspective there are at least two possible explanations for that:
  - The locals know and just don't care to report it. Especially since Gaea is one of the closest agricultural bases, Valkyrie may well depend on it for food and other supplies.
  - The Retros have become so powerful to just let their strength be known locally.

  The system Hind's Variable N. in-game canonically means Hind's Variable North and it is not a reference to the real world nebula Hind's Variable nebula.

4.5. Game mechanics

- Bartenders besides various rumors about everything conceivable can also provide information about local nav points or even about neighboring systems which may or not be accurate or they may be time sensitive.
- Bartenders may also have notes from other characters in the game e.g. Tayla or Lynch intended for the player.
- Communication with the bases may give access to local news or to recent in-universe developments.

4.6. Cut material

- A **fourth ship** intended to be a blockade runner or a fast courier ship.
- An entire **scene** when Brownhair finds the Steltek base.

4.7. Art

In this subsection I include *Privateer* art I made recently with the help of some AI, mostly for filters.





5. The Wing Commander Universe

Here I have some thoughts about the broader *Wing Commander* universe in general. They are not directly related to *Privateer*, but do they provide insight into that universe.

In overall, the main *Wing Commander* games become progressively darker. In WC1 the battle is tough but epic, WC2 is outright depressive and everyone considers Blair a traitor, WC3 feels as if defeat is only half a mission away, and in WC4 the Confederation is about to be taken over by authoritarianism. I haven't played *Prophecy* much, so I don't have many recollections from it.

Wing Commander 4 always felt not just like a movie to me, which was the intention all along, but like an 1990s action movie specifically. All the elements are there: The superweapon the bad guys have, the secret organization which threatens the Confederation, the high ranking inside man (Tolwyn), the 1990s hairstyle of Dr. Brody and of Barbara Miles, Robert Rusler, Chris Mulkay, and MarK Dacascos.

References

- **My article on Privateer on Serpentor's Lair**.
- **Wing Commander CIC**.
- **Privateer playtester's guide**.
- **Privateer on Wikipedia**.
- **Privateer on GOG**.
- **Privateer on Ars Technica**.
- **Privateer on tvtropes**

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